What to Notice in Mom's Mail, Statements and Care Bills, and How to Note It

Everyday things to notice and write down while you sort her paperwork, with no interpreting.

You're opening Mom's mail for the first time, and you're not sure what you're looking for. This guide names fifteen everyday things worth noticing in her mail, her statements, her care bills and around the house and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What an item means for paying for Mom's care is a question for your Medicaid planner or another professional who can look at her situation, and the notes you keep are what make that conversation useful. The things to look for follow lists published by the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, AARP, the Family Caregiver Alliance and the federal long-term care site; the wording about what to write down is ours.

In the mail

1 Who is writing to her [1]

NOTICE The banks, insurers, pension offices and agencies whose names are on the envelopes, including any that nobody in the family has mentioned.

WRITE DOWN Each name, what kind of mail it was (a statement, a bill, a notice), and the date on it.

2 Benefit and pension letters [2] [5]

NOTICE Letters about Social Security, a pension, veterans benefits or another regular payment.

WRITE DOWN Who pays it, how often, and the amount as the letter states it.

3 Letters that ask for something

NOTICE Any letter that asks Mom to reply, sign, renew or send something, or that says something is changing.

WRITE DOWN Who sent it, the date on it, and what it asks for, in its own words. Questions about it go to the office that sent it.

4 Insurance mail [3]

NOTICE Premium notices and yearly statements for life insurance, long-term care insurance or an annuity.

WRITE DOWN The company, the kind of policy, and where the policy itself is kept.

On the statements

5 The names on the account [4] [8]

NOTICE Exactly whose names are printed at the top of each statement: Mom alone, or Mom and someone else.

WRITE DOWN The names as printed, and the kind of account if the statement says. If it doesn't, ask the bank.

6 Money that arrives every month [5]

NOTICE Deposits that repeat: the same payer, around the same day.

WRITE DOWN The payer, the amount as shown, and the day it arrives. No totals.

7 Payments that leave automatically [1]

NOTICE Bills that are withdrawn from a checking account or charged to a credit card without anyone writing a check.

WRITE DOWN Who is paid, how much, and from which account.

8 Withdrawals, gifts and transfers that stand out

NOTICE A large withdrawal, a check to a family member, money moved between accounts, or anything nobody can explain.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount as shown, where it went if you know, and who might remember. Don't decide why, and don't undo anything. It goes on the list of questions for your Medicaid planner.

9 Accounts with no current paper [1]

NOTICE An account, a policy or a property that shows up on a tax return or an old statement but has no recent statement in the pile.

WRITE DOWN What it was, where you saw it, and the date of the paper you saw it on.

On the care bills

10 The basic charge [6]

NOTICE The main charge on the bill from the facility or care provider, and the dates it covers.

WRITE DOWN The charge as printed, the period it covers, and the date of the bill.

11 What is billed separately [6]

NOTICE Any line beyond the basic charge. Facilities may charge extra for services beyond the basic room, food and housekeeping, and home care is generally more expensive in the evening, on weekends and on holidays.

WRITE DOWN Each line as printed, with a question mark beside any you don't understand. Those go to the business office.

12 Who paid, and from where [7] [8]

NOTICE Which account each care bill was paid from, and whether a family member paid any of it from their own money.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount, the account, and who paid. Keep the receipt.

Around the house

13 Deeds, titles and registrations [3]

NOTICE The deed to the house, vehicle titles and registrations, and the names printed on each.

WRITE DOWN What it is, the names as printed, and where the paper is kept.

14 The places paper lives [3]

NOTICE A safe deposit box key, a home safe, a second desk, a folder at a relative's house.

WRITE DOWN Each place, what is kept there, and who can get to it.

In conversation

15 What Mom and the family mention [1] [2]

NOTICE A pension from an old employer, a policy “from years ago,” an account at another bank, money lent or given, a name added to an account.

WRITE DOWN Who said it, the date, and their own words. Mark it “said, not confirmed” until the paper turns up.

When a note isn't enough

Some things on this list need a person as well as a note. A bill or a letter you don't understand goes to the office that sent it. Withdrawals, gifts or transfers nobody can explain go to your Medicaid planner as questions, without anyone deciding first what they mean. And if anyone is thinking of changing a joint account, or of any decision that may affect Medicaid eligibility, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says to get legal advice first. An elder law attorney is the person for that.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, whether anything counts for Medicaid, or whether Mom may qualify for anything. It isn't legal, financial or tax advice. The professionals answer those questions, and they do it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed and written down. The planning interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Where to Find My Important Papers
4. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Considering a financial caregiver? Know your options
5. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility
6. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Costs of Care
7. AARP, Legal Checklist for Caregivers With Aging Parents

8. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney